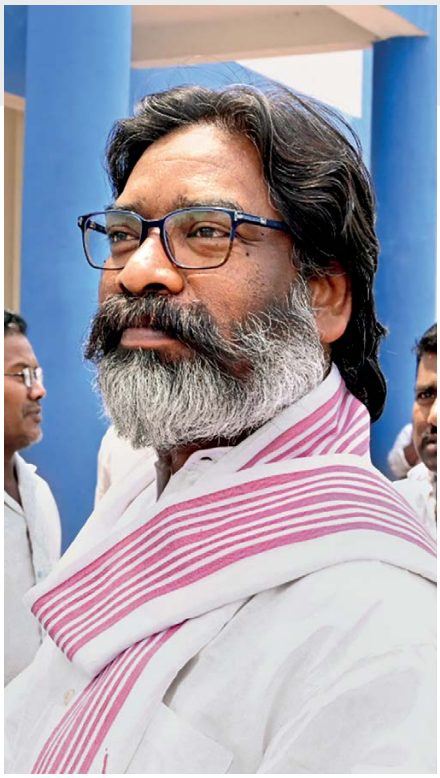






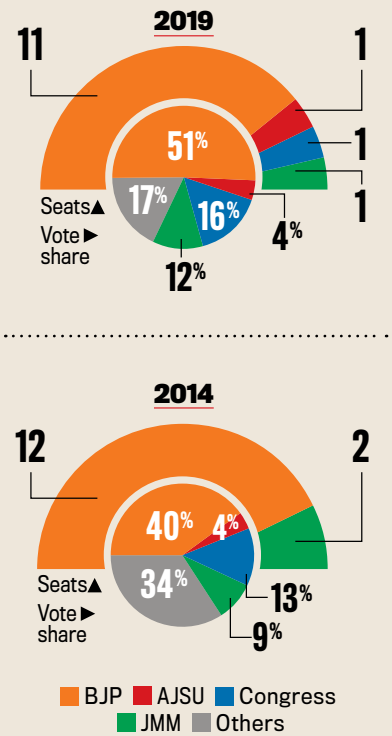
Photographs by SOMNATH SEN

SAFFRON REIGN

The BJP swept Jharkhand in 2014 as well as 2019. What will 2024 bring?

LOK SABHA POLLS

(Total seats: 14)



Vote share figures have been rounded off

POLL PROTAGONISTS
(Clockwise from above) Jharkhand CM Champai Soren with Kalpana Soren in Sahibganj on May 10; Hemant Soren at his uncle's funeral on May 6; and PM Modi at a rally in Ranchi on May 3

whether the BJP's anti-corruption narrative will help it steal a march over its rivals in Jharkhand, given the public resentment against Soren's arrest, especially among the state's tribal community of which the former CM is a part and which comprises over 26 per cent of the state electorate, according to the 2011 Census. The STs exert significant influence in Jharkhand, with five of the state's 14 Lok Sabha seats and 28 of the 81 assembly seats being reserved for tribal candidates. The BJP's allusions to the Congress-JMM's alleged corruption are being seen as an attempt by the party to assuage the public disapproval over the action taken against former CM Hemant Soren, but whether the voters approve of it by voting the BJP remains to be seen. According to political observers, the BJP's biggest strength, the Modi wave among voters, is missing in Jharkhand this year.

The Congress-JMM-RJD combine, part of the INDIA bloc, has kept its focus firmly on tribal rights in the state. Campaigning for JMM candidate Joba Majhi in Singbhum on May 7, Congress MP Rahul Gandhi said, "The tribals have the first right to Jharkhand's water, forest and land. No one can snatch it away. If Modi comes to power, he will give water, forest and land to Adani [businessman Gautam Adani] and send the tribals to beg. But, our government will uplift everyone." Pres-